# Communication Checker Guidelines

The DESS App is our primary platform for communication across the primary schools and College. Any initial school communication, whether that is to an individual, class/form, whole school etc must be sent via the communication request form. Once submitted, the Marketing & Communications Team will reach out to you if they have any further questions before sending the communication via the app. If you have any questions with regards to the form, please email commsrequests@dess.sch.ae.

**Things to consider for each question on the Communication Request Form:**

1. Department

   Please consider which department the message is coming from.

2. Extension Number

   Please include your extension number in case there is a follow-up question.

3. Which school is your message for?

   Please include the school(s) the communication is intended for.

4. Which member of SLT has approved your message?

   The SLT member you have selected must approve the message BEFORE you send it via the form.

5. Please select who your message is for?

   If your message is for a whole school, full year group, full class, full set or full form, there is no need to submit an Excel spreadsheet.

6. If you have selected a full year group, class or form please state what this is here.

   For example, a Year 5 or Year 6 Blue. Or mention your Set - **DESS College only**.

7. When would you like your communication sent out?

   Please give as much notice as possible (ideally 48 hours' notice). Please work alongside the department(s) you represent and coordinate when their messages are to be sent out in advance of submitting the form. **Please avoid communication going out on a Friday. Please know that your message will be sent out on the date you have selected, unless we contact you and say otherwise.**

8. When would you like your communication archived (removed from the app)?

   Please consider the archive date carefully. For example, if the message is regarding an event, please select the archive date as the day **AFTER** the event. Also, **please don't keep your message live on the app longer than necessary, e.g. to the end of the term.**

9. If you'd like to set 1-3 reminders for your message, please add the relevant date(s).

10. Please upload the following:

1. If you are sending your message to selected students, please use the Excel spreadsheet template given. **Only submit one list, under one tab in alphabetical order by surname first.** Include only:
    - Surname (taken from iSAMS).
    - First name (official iSAMS name and **not** preferred name) – please take this list from iSAMS only.
    - Class/Form.
    - **If your message is to 2 schools (e.g. both the primaries), please submit the Excel Spreadsheets separately.**
2. Your message:
    - Use the Word template given.
    - Make sure the title and short description are within the 50 characters stated.
    - Make sure the title and short description are different.
    - If your message is year group specific, please **start your title with the year group** e.g. **Y10 Portugal Trip**.

11. Add any additional notes to consider when publishing your message.

Please add any additional information here, e.g. if you would like your message posted at a certain time.

**Additional information**

**Naming Our Schools**

To ensure clarity for parents, please use the official school names only:

- **DESS Oud Metha** – may be shortened to *Oud Metha*. - ***DO NOT USE DOM***
- **DESS Academic City** – may be shortened to *Academic City*. - ***DO NOT USE DAC***
- **DESS College** – may be shortened to *the College*.

DESS (without College/Oud Metha/Academic City) should only be used when referring to the family of schools. Please avoid alternatives such as DAC, DOM, DESC, DESS Primary, DESS AC/OM, or "DESS Schools." Using consistent names helps parents navigate information correctly and reinforces our shared identity.

**Communication Guidelines – PLEASE READ CAREFULLY**

**To help us manage parent messages efficiently and maintain high standards, please:**

1. Allow **48 hours' notice** before your message is due to go out and please **avoid** communication going out on a Friday.
2. Check all **spelling, grammar and tone** before submission.
3. Check the number of characters in the title (50 characters max).
4. Make sure the font is Montserrat and all text (including merge fields) are the same font size.
5. If there is a date included, e.g. if it is an event, parents' evening etc, **ensure the date is in the parent calendar**.

6. If an update is required, email in first to inform us and then **resubmit the full form** with the correct information rather than emailing changes separately.
7. If you are regularly sending out the same type of communication, **please formulate a template**, e.g. each sporting fixture to have the same layout/information where possible.

**Body of the text**

8. Make sure the **title and short description are different and within the character limit.**
    a. Don't include a '&' symbol in the title.
    b. **Consider the short description to be a date, e.g. Wednesday, 7th January.**
9. Keep the message **concise, clear and parent-friendly**—avoid phrases like *"I hope this email finds you well"* or *"If you are receiving this letter…"*.
10. Messages should **not start with, Dear Parent, Dear Sports parents etc.**
11. Message should be in **black only**. No other colour, e.g. red. **Use bold instead to highlight key points.**
12. **Include hyperlinks** within the body text (not embedded in images or as separate documents).
13. Check your **links work** e.g. open your Microsoft Form in an incognito window.
14. Write 'at' instead of '@' e.g. at DESS Academic City and not @ DESS Academic City.
15. There should only be **one space** after a full stop.
16. Don't include QR codes within the body of the text, only links.
17. Include **bullet points only**. No emoji's or symbols.
18. **Money amounts** should be displayed, for example AED3000 – no space between AED and the number, and nothing displayed after the number.
19. **No capital letters or red text** anywhere – in the body of the text or the title.
20. **Don't add any unnecessary spacing** between details and add a colon, e.g. Time: 8.00am.
21. Emphasise any **key details in the text in bold**, e.g. date, location etc.
22. **British English language only**, no American English.
23. Please refer to the children/students as '**children**' (not students/pupils) at the primaries, and '**students**' at the college.
24. To include a link, it should read – please fill out the form **HERE**. Please add the hyperlink within the word **HERE**.
25. Attachments should only be **PDF files** (no PowerPoints or reformatted Word-to-PDF files).
26. Please can **any dates be written in full**, e.g. **Thursday, 6th November** and not 6/11/25.
27. **Dates should read Thursday, 6th November (don't forget the comma after the day)**
28. Do not use 24-hour clock, times should be written as **7.45am not 7:45am**.
29. All communication **will not include a sign off** unless sent from an individual teacher. If so, then please include the below.
    Kind regards,
    **Mr/Mrs/Miss XXXX (no dot added after Mr etc.)**
    **Title**
    **No Yours faithfully, Yours sincerely** etc.
30. Check any dates within your original message e.g. deadline dates haven't passed.
31. If you add an attachment, please check the attachment and make sure it's **named correctly** and on the **school templates** e.g. Word template, PowerPoint template, etc.
32. Use the **Microsoft Forms template given** – make sure the times/dates are listed for each event and match what is on the form with the body of the text.
33. For PE/Sport kits, please **say 'school kit' or 'school sports kit'**, not DESS sports kit etc.

**Personalised communication / using merge fields**

*Merge fields should be included in every piece of communication unless the audience is the whole school. Wherever possible, please personalise communications and replace the word "parent" with "you", as we are addressing the parent directly.*

Please replace all mentions of 'your child', 'your son/daughter', 'they', 'their' etc. with the correct merge field within the body of the text.

Please make sure the merge field reflects the rest of the text. For example, if the neighbouring text is in bold or Italic, please make sure the merge field is the same. Please also check the spacing AFTER the merge field (make sure there is only one space between the merge field and the neighbouring word).

| Merge Field | Outcome |
|---|---|
| {{student.forename}} | Forename |
| {{student.forename_apostrophe_s}} | Forename's |
| {{student.his/student.her}} | his/her |
| {{student.His/student.Her}} | His/Her |
| {{student.him/student.her}} | him/her |
| {{student.Him/student.Her}} | Him/Her |
| {{student.himself/student.herself}} | himself/herself |
| {{student.He/student.She}} | He/She |
| {{student.he/student.she}} | he/she |
| {{pupil.txtacademichouse}} | Pupil Academic House |

If you require an additional merge field, please let us know.

**Excel Spreadsheet**

1. Use the **attached Excel template** for audience lists:
    a. One sheet only (no extra tabs).
    b. Please make sure the list is taken directly from iSAMS (spelling mistakes are currently occurring).
    c. Listing official surname, iSAMS first name (not preferred names) and class/form in separate columns.
    d. Listed in alphabetical order by surname.
    e. Please **check for spelling mistakes and duplicates** before submitting.
2. If your message is to **2 schools** (e.g. both the primaries), please submit the Excel Spreadsheets separately.
3. Please **create a custom group** when necessary. Please allow up to 24 hours between creating a custom group in iSAMS and it appearing in the app's CMS. This allows sufficient time for the group to sync across systems before it can be used within the app.

**Branded Templates Available on SharePoint** (Please use where necessary. All attachments must be branded and saved/submitted as pdfs)

- Word documents
- PowerPoint presentation
- Microsoft Forms (link)

If you have any questions, please email commsrequests@dess.sch.ae.